

Practice Paper 48 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Listening “like a song he is unlikely to hear again”

1 mark for recognising that the narrator is **aware this is the last time** he will hear the alarm in this familiar context.

1 mark for explaining the **quiet emotional weight** he gives the moment — he is paying **deliberate, almost wistful attention** to something he usually resents.

Sample answer: The comparison shows that the narrator is fully conscious that this morning is his **last** such morning, and he is treating an ordinary sound with the **tender, reflective attention** one usually gives to something precious that is about to disappear.

Q2. [2] — “Letters, like men, eventually wear away”

1 mark — He is comparing the **fading stitched name** on his overalls to his **own ageing body and working life**.

1 mark — It suggests he sees himself as **worn down by time**, gradually being **erased** from the workplace, just as the embroidery is fading from the cloth.

Q3. [2] — Sensory attachment to the factory

1 mark each for any two of:

- The **smell** of “machine oil”, “warm rubber”, and the “faintly bready scent of cardboard boxes”.
- He says he will “miss [the smell] more than anything else”.
- He **nods to the security guard**, suggesting a long, familiar daily routine.
- He refers to Bay 14 as a place where “the conveyor and I had spent the better part of my life”, treating the machine as a companion.

Q4. [2] — The robotic arm

(a) [1]: He calls the feeling **foolish** because he knows, **rationally**, that a machine has **no consciousness, no intention and no eyes**; he is aware that he is **projecting** human qualities onto a piece of equipment.

(b) [1]: The word **waiting** suggests he sees the arm as a **patient successor** — almost a quiet replacement standing by to take his place, which gives him a slight unease.

Q5. [2] — Why “mindless” is wrong

1 mark — Repetitive work, when done for many years, develops a **specific, refined skill** in the hands — a kind of **practised intelligence** that outsiders fail to notice.

1 mark — This skill is **quiet and invisible**; no one writes about it or celebrates it, but it is **real** and **valuable**, and only those who have done the work can recognise it.

Q6. [3] — Foreman’s respect (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the comparison to “a man at prayer” gives the moment a **sacred, reverent quality**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- He **waits** until the narrator has “finished the piece in [his] hand” — he respects the narrator’s work and does not interrupt it.
- He **says nothing maudlin** — he refuses to embarrass the narrator with sentimentality.
- He shakes hands **in silence**, then says only “Twenty years, Yusoff” — the brevity itself is dignified.
- He **looks at the floor** for a moment — a small, private gesture of emotion that shows he is moved.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “Bitterness... a poor companion to take into retirement”

1 mark — It shows he is **self-aware** and **philosophical**: he understands that bitterness would **poison** the years ahead of him.

1 mark — It reveals **quiet strength and dignity** — he refuses to let the loss of his job define him as a resentful man.

Q8. [2] — “A polite shadow”

1 mark — **Unusual**: A machine is normally described in cold, mechanical terms, not as something with manners; the word **polite** applies to a person, not an object.

1 mark — **Suggestion**: The narrator feels **no hostility** towards the arm — he treats it as a **quiet, well-mannered presence** rather than an enemy, which underlines his refusal to be bitter.

Q9. [1] — Preserving dignity at the end

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- He wiped his station “more carefully than [he] had ever wiped it down before”.
- He **folded his cloth** and **took his mug from its hook** with care.
- He **tidied his locker** as though preparing it for a successor.
- He left a folded note saying “Be good to the line. The line has been good to me.”

Q10. [2] — “Small” and “surprising”

1 mark — **Small:** The peace is **modest, not triumphant**; he does not feel grand emotion, only a quiet steadiness — appropriate to a humble working man.

1 mark — **Surprising:** He had **not expected** to feel peaceful at all; he might have anticipated grief or anger, and is mildly astonished by his own calm.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **calm, resigned, dignified, peaceful, quietly resolute**. (Reject: **sad, bitter, angry** — these miss the composed quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — What is actually difficult about rare earths

1 mark — The elements exist in **reasonable quantities** in the earth's crust; they are **not** geologically scarce.

1 mark — The real challenge is **extracting them in useful concentrations** and **refining them** into the powders, magnets and alloys that industry needs.

Q13. [2] — Two product categories that depend on rare earths

1 mark each for any two different categories of:

- **Electric vehicles** (neodymium magnets in motors).
- **Wind turbines** (large neodymium magnets in generators).
- **Military hardware** — fighter aircraft, guided missiles, submarines (terbium and dysprosium in actuators and sonar).
- **Consumer electronics and medical equipment** — mobile phones, hospital scanners.
- **Polishing compounds for glass screens.**

Q14. [1] — Tone of “sobering”

1 mark — **Concerned / serious / alarmed.** It shows the writer is **not amused or excited** but rather **uneasy**, because the list reveals how **dependent** the modern world has become on a small set of materials.

Q15. [2] — How one country came to dominate (own words)

1 mark each for any two of:

- Long-term **government support / industrial subsidies** given to processing plants.
- A **willingness to tolerate environmental pollution** that other countries would not accept.
- A **deliberate strategy of low pricing** (in the 1990s and 2000s) that **forced foreign competitors out of business.**

Reject answers that copy phrases such as “patient industrial policy” or “tolerated pollution”.

Q16. [2] — Tone of “outsourced both the dirty work and the technical know-how”

1 mark — The tone is **critical / disapproving / accusatory**: the writer is **blaming** Western governments for their own predicament.

1 mark — The phrase **dirty work** implies they were **willing to let others bear the pollution**, while losing the **expertise** makes their dependence **self-inflicted and short-sighted.**

Q17. [2] — “Clean technologies... built upon a dirty foundation”

1 mark — **Clean technologies**: products such as electric vehicles and wind turbines that **reduce pollution** during their use.

1 mark — **Dirty foundation**: the **mining and refining** that produces the rare earths inside them

is itself **highly polluting** — generating radioactive waste rock, toxic effluent and contaminated water. The “greenness” of the product is **undermined** by the dirtiness of its origin.

Q18. [2] — The more difficult step after opening a mine

1 mark — **Step:** Building a **refinery** that can chemically **separate the seventeen very similar elements** at industrial scale.

1 mark — **Why hard:** It requires **large capital, specialised expertise**, and a **willingness to accept the environmental risks of refining** — none of which Western countries have so far been fully prepared to provide.

Q19. [2] — Bottleneck “no longer technical but logistical”

1 mark — **Technical:** The **science** of recovering rare earths from used motors, hard disks and lighting has been **largely solved** — pilot plants achieve good recovery rates.

1 mark — **Logistical:** The remaining difficulty is **practical organisation** — **collecting, sorting and transporting** enough used products, at sufficient purity, to **supply a full-scale recycling plant**.

Reject lifts of “collecting and sorting” without rewording.

Q20. [1] — Closing question about democratic patience

1 mark — The writer is **sceptical / doubtful**: he suspects that governments facing **short election cycles** will struggle to fund unprofitable mines, refineries and stockpiles through long periods of low prices, and so a secure supply may **not actually be achieved**.

Q21. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Problems caused by reliance on rare-earth metals (Paragraphs 3–4):

1. **Supply is heavily concentrated** in a single dominant producer country (around 60% of mining, 80%+ of refining).
2. This dependence is **strategically dangerous** for Western governments — they rely on one supplier for essential materials.
3. **Mining** produces large amounts of **waste rock** containing **low-level radioactive material**.
4. **Refining** uses **acids and solvents** that create **toxic effluent**, contaminating **rivers and groundwater** (e.g. Baotou’s tailings lake).

Steps now being taken to secure supply (Paragraphs 5–7):

5. **New mines** are being opened in countries such as Australia, the United States, Vietnam, Greenland and Tanzania (**diversification**).
6. Building **refineries** in friendly jurisdictions to separate the elements at scale.
7. **Recycling** end-of-life motors, hard disks and lighting to recover the same magnets.
8. Holding **long-term strategic stockpiles** and **sustaining political/financial support** across years of low prices.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

The reliance on rare-earth metals creates problems because almost all mining and refining is controlled by one country, leaving other nations strategically exposed. Extracting and refining these elements also produces radioactive waste rock and toxic chemical effluent that poisons soil and water near processing towns. To reduce these risks, governments are now opening fresh mines on several continents, financing cleaner refineries, recovering magnets from used motors and electronics, and holding strategic stockpiles supported by patient long-term funding.

Length count: 78 words from “The” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —